

Playing Scales With the Left Hand

Every serious piano accordionist worth their salt should learn how to play basic melodies with their left hands. Playing melodies with the left hand allows piano accordionists to add more textures and layers to pieces. Here, I'll be talking only about piano accordions that utilize the [Stradella bass system](#), so you'll be limited to just the first two columns of buttons (the two columns closest to the bellows).

Stradella bass system layouts are designed to make it pretty easy to play major scales and all of their associated modes (including the natural minor scale). It's significantly more challenging to play scales like harmonic and melodic minor scales and their modes and also diminished and augmented scales, especially when you need to play two full octaves instead of just one.

With the left hand, you're limited because you're not able to use your thumb (at least as far as I can tell – maybe someone will prove me wrong). Therefore, you can't really do finger crosses like you can with the right hand.

Like with the right hand, don't use the same finger for two different keys that are played quickly in succession.

Playing two octaves consecutively is a good habit to get into (for the right hand too) because when you only play one octave, you don't build the muscle memory for the transition between the last couple of notes of a scale to the first couple of notes of a scale. Learning all the modes of a scale will generally build this habit too. Make sure to practice both ascending and descending scales.

When you're comfortable playing an entire scale with your left hand, practice playing the same scale with both hands at the same time. Eventually, you can practice more complex patterns such as playing the right hand a third or a sixth above the left hand. Similarly, for rounds like 'Row, Row, Row Your Boat', practice playing the normal melody on the beat with one hand and the offset melody with your other hand (make sure to do this exercise using both the left and right hands for the normal melody).

Finally, it's also good to learn how to play melodies with your left hand while accompanying these melodies with chords played by the right hand.